India's actions from a geo-strategic perspective. Why were some officials from the bureaucracy so opposed to the idea of engaging with the Taliban even after realising that India had lost out in Afghanistan? Was it simply an 'ideological stand'? While India's interpretation of the Taliban from its domestic context played a critical role, this was not the only reason for the partisan's dominance. India's close relations with Russia and traditional suspicion of the US added weight.

Foes from south?

Within ten hours of the hijacking, all three militants were escorted to Pakistan. Adding insult to injury, India received a bill of US$ 111,324 from the Taliban reclaiming costs towards food, fuel, and other services rendered towards flight IC-814.[164] Unsurprisingly, India's anger at the Taliban, only grew. The juxtaposition of the Taliban's narratives on the hijacking incident, however, also highlight the strong biases in India's own interpretation of the situation. To be clear, despite being opposed to the Taliban, India officially thanked them for their 'correct' approach as mediators.[165] Singh was 'gratified to report that the Taliban is fully cooperating with the relief team and the negotiating team'.[166] Even Khalili, Rabbani's emissary to India and a die-hard anti-Taliban advocate said, 'the Taliban are not beasts, they are also human beings.'[167] In fact, there were many instances during the negotiations when the Taliban pressured the hijackers to alter their demands and propose a blanket deal rather than a piecemeal approach to the release of the hostages.[168] However, India also blamed the Taliban for allowing the three militants to leave Afghanistan, and for having 'sympathies' with the hijackers.[169] The Taliban's stance and involvement in the crisis underwent several stages.[170] Having never dealt with such a situation before, they were both worried about an impending foreign policy disaster on their soil but also hopeful of turning it into an opportunity to win international acclaim.

As mentioned above, the Taliban had no role in the planning or execution of the hijacking. According to Syed Akbar Agha, former head of the Jaish-ul-Muslimeen and a close aide of Mullah Omar, 'the plane was hijacked by the Pakistanis and not under the guidance of the Taliban. And if we see the negative